HACKATHON PITCH · [EVENT NAME]

The day's AI news, checked and read to you.

A pipeline that turns thousands of feed entries into one short, sourced podcast episode every morning.



[TEAM NAME] · [MEMBER NAMES]

THE PROBLEM

Keeping up with AI has become a second job.

On one ordinary day, 11 October 2026, the 41 sources we follow carried **7,459 feed entries**.

WHAT WE ARE WASTING

Almost everything published is not worth your attention

7,459	entries in the feeds of 41 sources
176	recent enough and actually about AI
43	new since the previous episode
39	separate stories, once the duplicates are grouped
12	**worth telling**, in the editor's judgement

HOW MUCH WE ARE WASTING

Two hours of reading, for news that fits in fourteen minutes

126 min to read the source articles behind those 12 stories

14 min to hear the episode made from them

WHY THIS IDEA

The usual ways of keeping up each leave a gap

Scrolling feeds

Thousands of entries a day. Most are repeats of one story, or not about what you need.

Newsletters

Still reading, still screen time. Each covers its own corner, so you end up with several.

Asking a chatbot

Fast, but it can state things no source said, and you cannot tell which parts.

Missing: something **short**, **spoken**, and **traceable to its sources**.

One episode a day. Every sentence traced to a source.

A machine does the reading, sorting and writing. A person still approves what goes out.

WHAT IT GIVES

Each morning the system hands over four things

episode.mp3

The spoken episode. 14 minutes on 11 October, 21 minutes the day before.

newsletter.md

The same stories in the same order, for people who would rather read.

show-notes.md

Every story's source links, each labelled confirmed, reported or rumour.

review.md

What was chosen, what was cut and why, and what the run cost. A person signs off here.

HOW IT WORKS

Twelve steps, from raw feeds to a finished episode

GATHER

1 Start
Freeze the day's settings

2 Fetch
Read 41 feeds and sites

3 Clean
Keep what is recent and about AI

JUDGE

4 Group
Merge reports of one event

5 Score
An editor model rates and ranks

6 Select
Apply the rules, read the articles

WRITE

7 Plan
Order the stories, set lengths

8 Write
Script from the sources only

9 Check
Cut what the sources do not back

DELIVER

10 Voice
Speak it on a local graphics card

11 Assemble
Build newsletter and notes

12 Package
Write the review sheet

Only steps 4, 5 and 8 call a language model. The other nine are ordinary code, so they cost nothing and behave the same way every time.

THE EDITOR

A model makes the list, and code holds it to the rules

THREE PASSES BY THE MODEL

1. Rate and rank
Eight ratings per story, then a final ranked list with a reason for each place.

2. Recovery
Every story left out is looked at again and either brought back or given a reason.

3. Lighter side
Up to three odd or viral stories, judged on their own terms.

RULES THE MODEL CANNOT OVERRIDE

- A story already told returns only when something new has happened.
- One late mention of an old story is not enough to revive it.
- Anything under the minimum score stays out.
- News older than three days is refused.

THE CHECK

Nothing is said that the sources did not say

Written from the article text
The writer is given the stored source articles and nothing else to draw on.

Names and numbers are verified
A sentence with a name or figure that is not in its sources is removed.

Every story carries a label
Confirmed by the organisation itself, reported by the press, or a rumour.

5

sentences removed on 11 October

Three were false alarms: the check mistook ordinary capitalised words for names. It is built to cut when in doubt.

THE STACK

Built from small parts that can each be swapped

Job	What does it	Where it runs
Pipeline	Python, one command	The laptop
Memory	SQLite, a single file	The laptop
Spotting duplicates	bge-small embedding model	The laptop, free
Editing and writing	Claude Sonnet 5.5	Cloud API, paid per use
Voice	Chatterbox Turbo	The laptop's graphics card
Safety net	243 automated tests	The laptop

One paid service. Everything else runs on a single machine with no server to keep alive.

PROOF

One real run, 11 October 2026

40 of 41
sources answered

39
stories rated by the editor

12
stories in the episode

14.0 min
of finished audio

56
requests to the language model

$0.47
total cost of the run

COST

A dollar or less a day, on one laptop

$0.47 11 October, 12 stories

$1.00 10 October, 25 stories

At those two rates, a month of daily episodes comes to roughly **$14 to $30**.

WHERE THE 47 CENTS WENT

Work	Cost
Rating and ranking	$0.24
Writing the script	$0.14
Judging duplicates	$0.09
Voice, run locally	$0.00

Model costs as recorded per request · monthly figure is an estimate

WHAT COMES NEXT

Working today, with a short list still to do

WORKING NOW

- The full run, feeds to finished audio, from one command.
- Five days of real episodes, 7 to 11 October.
- A fact check and a review sheet on every run.
- A run that stops midway picks up where it left off.

NEXT

- Publish to Spotify and Amazon Music through one RSS feed.
- Host-and-guest episodes in two voices; a 37-minute test exists.
- Recognise a follow-up to a story told more than three days ago.
- A narrator's voice we hold the rights to.

THANK YOU

Fourteen minutes, and you are caught up.

[What you are asking the judges for: feedback, a prize category, mentors, users]



[TEAM NAME] · [CONTACT OR LINK]